dimensions took more time to unfold. But the USSR's ideological linkages with China continued even when under strain, thereby limiting its role in the 1962 events.

In an interesting way, non-alignment also impacted the bilateral-multilateral balance of Indian diplomacy. The pursuit of a global profile sometimes came at the cost of narrower national interests. Eventually, an obvious exercise in increasing international influence ended up as a fatal diversion. The commitment of key players to UN duty in 1960 during Nehru's visit to Pakistan and again in 1962 as the China front deteriorated spoke volumes on Indian priorities. The moment of truth, of course, was the 1962 conflict itself. Both its preparations and actual conduct affirmed the inadequacy of India's understanding of power.

We tend to assume that the events in the period leading up to 1962 were predestined. In fact, the narrative of a 'betrayal' was designed to mitigate responsibility for a policy disaster at the highest levels. It took such deep root that the subsequent demonization of China has stood in the way of an objective analysis of India-China relations in this period. Independent of the justification for boundary claims, there are some issues that need to be addressed in the context of India's larger posture vis-à-vis China.

There was a genuine debate within the Indian system whether in the aftermath of the 1950 Chinese move into Tibet we should have initiated steps to finalize what had now become a common border. This is not an entirely hypothetical issue because serious suggestions to this end were made by very senior policymakers. Sardar Patel's famous letter to Prime Minister Nehru was part of this internal discourse. However, in what presumably was a desire to avoid immediate friction, the decision made was to postpone such engagement. At that time, China was more isolated internationally and its own position on Tibet had not hardened as it did after 1959. More than the issue itself, what comes out is a tendency to postpone a difficult issue. Avoiding hard choices was true in respect of the nuclear option as well. The same mindset led to the limited involvement of the military leadership in decision-making during the 1962 conflict. Instead, at the first sign of setback, we turned to others for both advice and assistance.